

V-TAPP · V-LAUNCHPAD · VIT-AP IIEC & VTBIF

Startup Survivor

Everything your team needs to compete: what to submit, when it's due, how the market decides who wins, and how not to get disqualified.

Participant Guide

Read this before the event

6 hours

4 market ticks

100 points

from documents

The 60-second version

You run a startup. Every **45 minutes** the market simulates a "tick" — you set a price, a marketing budget, and who you're selling to, and the market tells you how you did. You do that four times.

Halfway through, a **market shock** hits everyone at once. You then get a limited window to **pivot** and explain why. That pivot is worth more points than anything else in the event.

Judges grade every document you submit. Those grades don't just sit on a scoresheet — **they change how the market treats you**. A well-argued idea genuinely makes customers easier to win.

THE SINGLE MOST IMPORTANT THING

Clicking faster does **nothing**. There is no advantage to refreshing, spamming buttons, or being quick on the draw. Every tick runs for every team at the same moment. What matters is the quality of your thinking and hitting your deadlines.

How a tick works

Each 45-minute tick has three phases. You only act in the first one.

0–20 min YOU: submit your strategy + pricing doc
20–45 min JUDGES: review and grade everything
45 min MARKET: the tick fires for everyone at once

- 1 Submit a request.** Set your price, your marketing spend, and your target segment. Attach a **Pricing Justification** Google Doc explaining why, with at least 2 citations.
- 2 A judge approves or rejects it.** This is the only document that gets a yes/no. Everything else is graded for points.
- 3 Deploy unlocks.** The button is dead until a judge approves you. Once it lights up, click it.
- 4 The market runs** and the leaderboard moves.

YOU CANNOT LOSE A TICK BY WAITING

If a judge approves you and you never click Deploy, the system **auto-deploys for you** when the tick fires. Approval is the gate, not your reaction time.

What happens if you don't submit

SITUATION	WHAT THE MARKET DOES
You submitted nothing	Your previous approved strategy carries over . Nothing changes, you aren't punished beyond that.
You submitted, no judge got to it	Carries over. You are never penalised for a slow queue.
You were rejected and didn't resubmit	Carries over.
Approved but never clicked Deploy	Auto-deploys.

Missing the deadline isn't fatal

Pricing submissions are **never blocked by the clock**. If you're late you can still submit — it gets flagged **LATE** and a judge decides:

- accept it normally, or
- accept it with a **points penalty** (–10%, –25% or –50% of that tick's results), or
- **disqualify that tick** for you

So being late costs you something, but it's a judgement call rather than an automatic zero. Don't rely on it.

What you submit, and when

One document is due before each tick. Judges grade them as they arrive, so your points build up across the event instead of landing all at the end.

DOCUMENT	DUE BEFORE	POINTS	JUDGED BY
Idea & Problem Statement	Tick 1	15	rated
Pitch Deck	Tick 2 BEFORE HALFTIME	20	rated
Pivot Rationale	The pivot window	25	rated
Financial Model	Tick 3	10	rated
Go-to-Market Plan	Tick 3	10	rated
Final Pitch Deck	Tick 4	20	rated
Pricing Justification	Every tick	—	approved / rejected

100

TOTAL DOCUMENT POINTS

25

THE PIVOT ALONE

2

REVISIONS PER TICK

Format rules — read these, they cost people marks

- Everything is a **Google Doc link**. Paste the URL.
- Sharing must be set to **Anyone with the link** → **Viewer**. If it isn't, your submission is rejected immediately with an error telling you so.
- Each document shows its **required format** in the app — click "Required format" and follow the structure. Judges score against it.
- A citation means a **link plus one line saying what it proves**. A number with no source is an opinion.
- After you submit there's a **10-minute cooldown** before you can edit, and a maximum of **2 revisions** per tick.

EDITING YOUR DOC AFTER SUBMITTING DOES NOTHING

The moment you submit, the system takes a frozen snapshot. That snapshot is what the judge reviews and what gets stored. Changing the live Google Doc afterwards **cannot** change what was graded. Get it right before you hit submit.

Getting disqualified

SUBMIT AT LEAST ONE DOCUMENT BEFORE HALFTIME

When the halftime shock fires, any team that has submitted **zero** documents is **disqualified on the spot**. You keep your login but you can't submit, can't deploy, and you rank below every surviving team no matter how much money you made.

This is a participation check, not a quality bar. Submitting something mediocre keeps you in. Submitting nothing does not.

You are **not** cut for documents the judges simply haven't graded yet — that's on them, not you.

How the market actually decides

This isn't a slot machine. Every lever has a real trade-off, and the right answer changes when a shock lands. Understanding this is most of the game.

Price — there is no "best" price

Your customers are price-sensitive, and how sensitive depends on your segment. Overpricing loses volume faster than it gains margin. Underpricing burns your margin for customers who'd have paid more. There is a genuine sweet spot, and it's different for each segment and each track.

SEGMENT	BEHAVIOUR	GOOD FOR
Mass	Very price-sensitive, biggest pool	Volume plays at a keen price
Premium	Tolerates a high price	Margin plays
Niche	Barely cares about price, tiny pool	High price, low volume

Marketing builds awareness that decays

Marketing spend doesn't buy instant sales — it builds an **awareness stock**, and that stock **fades every tick**. Spend once and coast and you'll watch it drain away. Spend nothing at all and you're relying on word of mouth. There's a small organic floor so you're never at zero, but it isn't much.

You're competing for the same customers

Everyone on your track is fighting over one shared pool of customers. Your share depends on your awareness, your price, and your judge ratings *relative to theirs*. If a rival undercuts you, they take your customers. Your results are not computed in a vacuum.

Profit, not revenue

You are scored on what you actually **keep**. You can absolutely generate huge revenue and still lose money by buying it with marketing spend at a thin margin. Watch your cost of goods and your burn.

YOU CAN GO BROKE, AND IT COMPOUNDS

Cash can go **negative**. Below zero it becomes debt that grows 8% every tick. If your debt passes twice your starting budget you're **insolvent**: marketing is capped at zero and your market pull takes a lasting penalty. You're never kicked out — you always get another tick to claw back — but the hole is real.

Your document grades move the market

Points you earn from documents feed straight into how attractive you are to customers, worth up to a **±30% swing**. A strong, well-cited idea literally makes the market kinder to you. This is the main reason to take the documents seriously even though they feel like "paperwork".

Halftime and the pivot

After tick 2 The shock fires

Hits every team equally. No one is targeted.

Immediately Pre-shock documents lock

You can't rewrite your pitch around a shock you've already seen.

Immediately The cut runs

Teams with zero submitted documents are disqualified.

45 minutes The pivot window opens

Submit your Pivot Rationale. Worth 25 points — the biggest single score in the event.

The pivot document asks you to quote the shock, say exactly what you're changing and why that specifically answers *this* shock, and say what you're deliberately **not** changing. A pivot that ignores the shock, or one that changes everything in a panic, both score badly.

Judges may also fire **opportunities and problems** during the event. These always hit everyone equally — a judge cannot help or harm one team.

How you're scored at the end

Two halves, each out of 100, split evenly:

50%

MARKET PERFORMANCE

50%

DOCUMENT POINTS

Market performance is not raw rupees. Each tick you're scored 0–100 against the other teams on your track, and those four scores are **averaged**. That means all four ticks matter equally and one lucky tick can't carry you — but equally, one bad tick won't sink you.

Document points is your judge-awarded total out of 100.

Disqualified teams always rank below every surviving team, regardless of score.

Common questions

Does clicking Deploy faster help?

No. Not at all. Approval is the gate.

My pricing doc was rejected — what now?

Read the judge's reason, fix that specific thing, resubmit. You get 2 revisions per tick and the cooldown still applies, so don't burn them carelessly.

Can a judge target my team with a bad event?

No. There is no mechanism for it. Every event and power hits the entire field.

I made the most money — why am I not first?

Money is half the score at most, and market performance is scored per tick against your track rather than as a rupee total. Documents are the other half.

Can we be eliminated for going broke?

No. Insolvency hurts badly but you always get another tick. The only way out of the event is the halftime cut for submitting nothing.

Where do I see all this in the app?

Your dashboard has a **How to Play** button in the top bar with a condensed version of this guide, plus live countdowns showing when submissions close and when the next tick fires.

FIVE THINGS THAT DECIDE MOST PLACINGS

- 1.** Submit something before halftime — non-negotiable.
- 2.** Cite properly; uncited numbers get marked down.
- 3.** Submit early so you have room for a rejection and a resubmit.
- 4.** Don't buy revenue at a loss.
- 5.** Make the pivot genuinely answer the shock — it's 25 points.